

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN SWITZERLAND

Complete Community Opposition How-To

This guide is built around Switzerland's rare lever — direct democracy, the right of citizens to force a public vote on a constitutional amendment, a law, and, most powerfully for a local project, at the commune and canton — together with the strong autonomy of cantons and communes and the statutory appeal rights of environmental organisations. It names the tools you'll meet (the popular initiative and referendum, the commune and canton, the planning and environmental law, the appeal rights, the courts) in plain words, and is honest that direct democracy cuts both ways.

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

In the **Biber valley** near **Rothenthurm**, in the canton of Schwyz, the federal military planned an army training ground across roughly a hundred hectares of moorland — the country's largest upland moor. The local farmers, told in effect that their land would be taken, made an unlikely alliance with conservationists and did something Swiss citizens can do that almost no one else on Earth can: they launched a **popular initiative** to change the Constitution itself. The Federal Council was against them. The National Council was against them. The Council of States was against them. Every organ of government backed the training ground. And on **6 December 1987, the people overruled all of them — 57.8 percent** voted Yes, writing the protection of moors and moorland into the federal Constitution and making Switzerland the only country in the world to give its bogs constitutional protection. The training ground was never built. Ordinary people, farmers and environmentalists together, used the tools of direct democracy to beat their own government and save a landscape for good.

The Rothenthurm alliance of farmers and conservationists drew on the tools of Swiss direct democracy — a set few communities in the world possess. The **popular initiative** can change the Constitution, as it wrote moor protection into it; the **referendum** can strike a law; and at the **commune and canton** level, citizens can force a vote on a local project — the most common and powerful route. **Cantons and communes** hold strong autonomy over planning. **Planning and environmental law** governs projects. **Environmental organisations have a statutory right to appeal**, and protest, petition, and litigation are lawful. And the **courts** enforce it all. But these tools have real limits, and this guide states them plainly. **Direct democracy cuts both ways**: for every Rothenthurm, Swiss voters have rejected many environmental initiatives — proposals to curb traffic, promote renewables, or tighten protection that went down at the ballot box — and a **vote you lose can legitimise the very project you opposed**. Initiatives and referendums take **signatures, money, coalitions, and time**, and the government and industry campaign hard on the other side. So aim for what these tools can deliver, with the discipline and effort it takes to win a vote, and the judgement not to force one you'll lose.

The Whole Strategy in One Idea

A project backed by the whole government looks unstoppable, but Swiss citizens can force a vote and overrule it, and a chain breaks at its weakest link. A Swiss fight turns on **direct democracy** (the initiative, the referendum, the commune and canton ballot); on the **autonomy of cantons and communes**; on the **planning and environmental law**; on the **appeal rights** of organisations; and on the **courts**. Every one of

those is a link you can grab — and the ballot box, as at Rothenthurm, is the one that reaches highest. **Find the one closest to your hand and pull.**

Be Honest About Which Fight You're In

Before you spend months on this, work out your real situation:

- **If the public can be won, direct democracy is your sharpest lever** — a popular initiative overruled the whole government at Rothenthurm.
- **If it's a local project, the commune and canton ballot is the most powerful route** — Swiss direct democracy bites hardest at the local level.
- **If a law or a constitutional protection is the goal, use the referendum or the initiative** — but weigh the cost and the risk of losing.
- **If you might lose the vote, think hard** — a lost vote can legitimise the very project you opposed, so don't force one you can't win; use the appeal rights and the courts instead.

Read the whole guide once before you move. Two habits run through it: **use direct democracy — the initiative, the referendum, the commune and canton ballot — to force a vote and overrule the government, and weigh every vote carefully, because direct democracy cuts both ways and a loss can legitimise the project.** That's how Rothenthurm was won — and how a lost vote is avoided.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

To break the chain you have to see it — who decides, how a project moves, and who's watching.

Who Actually Decides

A project needs planning and environmental approvals, decided largely by the **cantons and communes**, which hold strong autonomy. But above them all stands **direct democracy**: citizens can force a vote — a **popular initiative** to amend the Constitution, a **referendum** to strike a law, and, most powerfully for a local project, a vote at the **commune or canton**. **Environmental organisations** can appeal decisions. The **courts** enforce the law. Know which of these you can reach — the ballot box, especially at commune and canton level, is the sharpest.

How a Project Moves — and Where You Jump In

The planning and environmental approvals. The project seeks its approvals from the commune and canton. *Your opening:* the planning and environmental law, and the organisations' appeal rights.

The commune and canton ballot. *Your opening — the most powerful for a local project:* force a vote at the commune or canton, where Swiss direct democracy bites hardest.

The referendum and the initiative. *Your opening — for a law or a lasting protection:* a referendum to strike a law, or a popular initiative to write protection into the Constitution, as at Rothenthurm.

The appeal rights and the courts. *Your opening:* the statutory appeal rights of environmental organisations, and the courts.

Follow the Money and the Permissions

Dig up three things. **Who's behind it and what it needs** — the approvals from the commune and canton, and the government and industry backing it. **Whether the public can be won** — because direct democracy

is your sharpest lever, but only if you can win the vote. **What coalition you can build** — because an unlikely alliance (farmers and environmentalists at Rothenthurm) is often what wins a Swiss vote.

Who's Supposed to Be Watching

Each is an ally or an arena. The **cantons and communes** decide the approvals and hold the local ballot. **Direct democracy** lets citizens overrule the government. **Environmental organisations** hold statutory appeal rights. The **courts** enforce the law. And Switzerland's **local communities, environmental organisations, and unlikely coalitions** are the forces that reach furthest — the alliance that beat the whole government at Rothenthurm.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

Size up the odds honestly. These are rough patterns, not promises, and a vote you lose can hurt you. What most moves them: whether the public can be won, whether you use the local ballot, and whether your coalition is broad.

What you do	Roughly works	How long	Cost	What "works" means
Just gather documents	5–10%	weeks	low	The base for everything else
Commune / canton ballot (local project)	35–60%	months–yr	low–mod	A local project stopped at the ballot
Popular initiative (constitutional)	25–50%	2–4 yr	mod	A protection written in (Rothenthurm)
Referendum (strike a law)	30–55%	1–2 yr	mod	A harmful law struck
Environmental orgs' appeal rights	30–55%	months–2 yr	low–mod	A decision overturned
Planning + environmental law	25–50%	months–yr	low	Conditions or refusal
Broad / unlikely coalition	30–55%	months–years	low	The breadth that wins a vote
Everything together (ballot + law + appeals)	40–65%	months–years	mod	Stopped at the ballot and in law
Forcing a vote you lose	—	—	—	Can legitimise the project — avoid

The levers that move the needle most are the **commune and canton ballot** (for a local project) and the **popular initiative and referendum** (for a law or lasting protection), backed by the **appeal rights** and the **courts**. Rothenthurm shows the ceiling (a popular initiative overruling the entire government and writing constitutional protection). The honest floor is that direct democracy cuts both ways — many environmental initiatives have lost, and a lost vote can legitimise the project. So aim for a project stopped at the ballot, a protection written in, an appeal won — and don't force a vote you can't win.

On cost: the commune and canton ballot, the appeal rights, and coalition-building are relatively affordable; a federal initiative or referendum takes signatures, money, and years. The great strength is direct democracy — citizens can overrule the whole government; the great requirement is the discipline to win a vote, the breadth of coalition it takes, and the

judgement not to force one you'll lose.

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Being against "the project" is weak. Being specific — this commune vote, this appeal, this constitutional protection — is strong. Answer five questions in writing.

1. What is it, and who's behind it? Name the project, the company or government body, and the approvals it needs from the commune and canton.

2. Is it local, or a matter of law? Whether it's a **local project** (the commune or canton ballot — the most powerful route) or a matter of **law or lasting protection** (a referendum or popular initiative). **The ballot box is your sharpest lever** — pick the right level.

3. Can the public be won? Honestly assess whether a **vote can be won**, because direct democracy cuts both ways and a lost vote can legitimise the project.

4. What stage is it at, and what's the opening? Is a planning approval in process (appeal it)? Can you force a commune or canton vote? Is a referendum or initiative the route? These are the openings.

5. What coalition can you build? Because an **unlikely, broad coalition** — farmers and environmentalists, as at Rothenthurm — is often what wins a Swiss vote.

What this looks like in real life. A government-backed project would take local land or a landscape, needing commune and canton approvals. The five questions yield: the government body and its approvals; a local project (the commune/canton ballot the sharpest route); a public that might be won with the right coalition; a planning approval to appeal and a vote to force; and an unlikely alliance of the affected and the environmentalists. That's the Rothenthurm pattern — build a broad coalition, force a vote at the right level, and win it — using the appeal rights and courts alongside.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION

The difference between a community that can win a vote and one that can't is a compelling, honest case. Build it in three layers.

Layer one: the harm and the case. Document what the project would **take or destroy** — the land, the landscape, the moor, the environment — with credible evidence, and shape the clear, honest case that can win a public vote and a broad coalition.

Layer two: the approvals and the appeal grounds. Get the **planning and environmental approvals**, and read them for the flaws and the grounds for an **appeal** by an environmental organisation.

Layer three: the political map. Identify the right **level for a vote** (commune, canton, or federal), whether the **public can be won**, and the **coalition** you can build. Walking into the ballot, the appeal, or the courts with a compelling case, the right level, and a broad coalition is what wins.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

- **The harm** — the land, the landscape, the environment the project would take — with credible evidence.
- **The planning and environmental approvals** — from the commune and canton.
- **The appeal grounds** — the flaws an environmental organisation can appeal.

- **The right level for a vote** — commune, canton, or federal.
- **The coalition** — the unlikely, broad alliance that wins a Swiss vote.

STEP 3: BUILDING LOCAL OPPOSITION

Documents give you a case; a broad, unlikely coalition that can win a vote gives you the power that beat the whole government at Rothenthurm. Build in four moves.

Build the unlikely, broad coalition. Rothenthurm was won by an alliance that should not have worked — conservative farmers and urban environmentalists together. Build that breadth: the affected landowners, the community, the environmentalists, across the usual divides, because breadth is what wins a Swiss vote.

Bring in environmental organisations and their appeal rights. Switzerland's **environmental organisations have a statutory right to appeal** decisions. Bring them in — for the appeal, the expertise, and the campaign.

Choose the right level, and win the vote. For a **local project**, the commune or canton ballot is the most powerful route; for a **law or lasting protection**, a referendum or popular initiative. Choose the level you can win, and run the disciplined campaign — signatures, money, coalition, time — a vote demands.

Build to last, and weigh the risk. A federal initiative can take years. Build clear roles, a secure archive, a way to decide together, and the discipline for a long campaign — and the judgement not to force a vote you'll lose, since a loss can legitimise the project.

STEP 4: DIRECT DEMOCRACY, THE COMMUNE & THE APPEAL RIGHTS

Switzerland's sharpest lever is direct democracy, backed by cantonal and communal autonomy and the appeal rights of organisations.

Direct Democracy — the Sharpest Lever

The Rothenthurm lever: **direct democracy** lets citizens force a vote and overrule the whole government. For a **local project**, the **commune or canton ballot** is the most common and powerful route, where Swiss direct democracy bites hardest. For a **law**, a **referendum** can strike it; for a **lasting protection**, a **popular initiative** can write it into the Constitution, as Rothenthurm wrote in moorland protection. Choose the level, and win the vote.

Cantonal and Communal Autonomy and the Planning Law

Use the strong **autonomy of the cantons and communes** over planning, and the **planning and environmental law**, to shape or refuse a project at the local level where decisions are really made.

The Appeal Rights and the Courts

Switzerland's **environmental organisations have a statutory right to appeal** decisions — a powerful, distinctive lever. Bring them in, and use the **courts** to overturn a flawed decision, alongside the ballot.

The Honest Limits — Direct Democracy Cuts Both Ways

Straight talk: direct democracy is a rare and powerful lever, but it **cuts both ways** — many environmental initiatives have lost, and a **vote you lose can legitimise the very project you opposed**; votes take

signatures, money, coalitions, and time, and the government and industry campaign hard. So use the levers — the ballot at the right level, the autonomy, the planning law, the appeal rights, and the courts — win the votes you can win, avoid the ones you'll lose, and count a project stopped at the ballot, a protection written in, and an appeal won as wins.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

A stack of documents wins nothing until you aim it.

Harm becomes a matter for the people. Not "we oppose the training ground" but *"they mean to destroy the country's largest moor — let the people decide,"* as at Rothenthurm.

A local project becomes a commune vote. *"This is our commune's decision — let us vote on it."*

A lasting protection becomes an initiative. *"Let us write the protection of our moors into the Constitution itself,"* as the people did.

A flawed approval becomes an appeal. *"This decision is flawed — the environmental organisations can and will appeal it."*

Match it to the venue: the harm and the case to the ballot and the public; the local project to the commune or canton vote; the lasting protection to the initiative; the flawed approval to the appeal rights and the courts. And always weigh whether the vote can be won.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY

In Switzerland, winning the public is decisive, because direct democracy puts the decision in the people's hands — but a lost vote can legitimise the project, so the campaign must be disciplined and honest. A free press makes the media front central.

Lead with the landscape and the people's choice, not procedure. Not "the planning approval was flawed" but "they mean to destroy the country's largest moor — and the people can overrule the whole government." Use your strongest material: the harm, the landscape, and the breadth of the coalition.

Work several audiences at once. Build the broad, unlikely coalition and win the commune, canton, or nation; and keep the campaign disciplined, because a vote is won or lost on the public case. Make it easy: clear evidence, a compelling landscape story, the breadth of support.

Two hard rules. Accuracy above all — one exaggeration can lose a vote. And build the broadest possible coalition — the farmers-and-environmentalists breadth that won Rothenthurm — because breadth wins Swiss votes.

EMAILS & LETTERS

Make them your own; keep them short, exact and calm; keep a copy of everything.

8A — Building the coalition.

Subject: An unlikely alliance for [place].

"We, [group], propose an alliance across our usual divides — the affected landowners, the community, and the environmentalists — to defend [place] against [project], as farmers and environmentalists saved

Rothenthurm. [Contact.]"

8B — Forcing a commune / canton vote.

Subject: Let the [commune/canton] vote on [project].

"We, citizens of [place], call for a vote at the [commune/canton] on [project], which would [take our land / destroy our landscape]. Let the people decide. [Contact.]"

8C — A popular initiative / referendum.

Subject: A [referendum / popular initiative] on [issue].

"We propose a [referendum to strike [law] / popular initiative to protect [place]], as Rothenthurm protected the moors. We ask you to join the signature drive and the coalition. [Contact.]"

8D — To an environmental organisation (appeal rights).

Subject: Appeal against [project] — [place].

"[Project] threatens [place], and its approval is flawed: [specifics]. As an organisation with the right to appeal, we ask you to challenge it. [Attach evidence.]"

8E — Objection in the planning process.

Subject: Objection — [project] at [commune].

"We, [group], object to [project]: [it takes our land / harms the environment; the approval is flawed]. We ask the commune and canton to refuse it. [Attach evidence.]"

8F — To the company / authority.

Subject: Opposition and a possible vote — [project].

"We are the community affected by [project] at [place]. It faces a broad coalition, a possible commune or canton vote, and an appeal — as the whole government's training ground was overruled at Rothenthurm. [Contact and evidence summary.]"

8G — Letter to the press.

Subject: They mean to destroy [landscape] — let the people decide.

"[Project] would [take/destroy] [landscape]. We can provide the harm, the landscape's value, and the breadth of our coalition. [Contact.]"

8H — Rallying the public (weigh the vote).

Subject: Our land, our vote — let's win it together.

"[Project] threatens [place]. At Rothenthurm, farmers and environmentalists together overruled the whole government with a popular vote. Let's build that breadth and win our vote — carefully, because a vote is worth forcing only when it can be won. [Contact.]"

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME OR FEW RESOURCES: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

If you must move fast and lean, do these six things, in order:

1. **Build the broadest, most unlikely coalition you can (8A).**
2. **Choose the right level for a vote — commune, canton, or federal.**
3. **Honestly assess whether the vote can be won — don't force one you'll lose.**
4. **Force the vote at the winnable level (8B/8C).**
5. **Bring in environmental organisations' appeal rights (8D), and object in planning (8E).**
6. **Run a disciplined, accurate campaign to win the public (8G/8H).**

Even lean, those six use direct democracy at the right level, with the breadth that wins — the Rothenthurm template.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

Switzerland's direct democracy is a rare lever, but it cuts both ways, and you must plan for it.

When the whole government backs the project. Rothenthurm proved the people can overrule the entire government with a popular vote. Build the broad coalition and force the vote at the right level.

When you might lose the vote. A lost vote can legitimise the very project you opposed. Assess honestly whether you can win; if not, don't force a vote — use the appeal rights, the planning law, and the courts instead.

When a vote takes signatures, money, and time. A federal initiative is a years-long, resource-heavy campaign. Weigh the cost, and prefer the commune or canton ballot for a local project, which is the most powerful and often the most winnable route.

When you need breadth. Swiss votes are won by breadth — the unlikely farmers-and-environmentalists alliance of Rothenthurm. Build across the usual divides.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO'S CAPTURED

Switzerland is, by repute, well-governed, so outright corruption is rare — but capture by industry interests and the underweighing of the environment are the real risks, and direct democracy is your ultimate guard.

How to spot it. Approvals against the evidence; planning shaped for a favoured developer; the environment underweighed; benefits to the connected while land and landscape bear the cost.

Who's supposed to guard against it. Switzerland's audit and oversight bodies examine public money and conduct. The **courts** and the **appeal rights** can overturn a flawed decision. And, above all, **direct democracy** lets the people overrule a captured decision at the ballot, as Rothenthurm overruled the whole government.

How to fight it safely. The issue here is usually bias or underweighing, not graft — so document precisely what an approval shows and understates, and keep every claim exact. Route serious evidence to the courts, the appeal rights, and trusted journalists, and, where the public can be won, take it to the ballot — the

ultimate Swiss check on a captured decision.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE

Don't run these steps one after another — run them together. The documented harm builds your case; direct democracy is the decisive lever; the broad coalition is the muscle; the planning law, the appeal rights, and the courts press it; the disciplined campaign wins the vote. Together they multiply. One at a time, or in a vote you lose, they fail.

Early on (weeks 1–8): document the harm; build the broad, unlikely coalition; choose the right level for a vote; assess whether it can be won; object in planning.

In the thick of it (months–years): bring in the appeal rights; force the vote at the winnable level; run a disciplined campaign.

The long haul (years, for an initiative): carry a referendum or initiative to the ballot; keep the coalition broad; hold the line for a project stopped at the ballot, a protection written in, and an appeal won.

FINAL ASSESSMENT

Stopping a destructive project in Switzerland can be done in a way few countries allow — farmers and environmentalists together overruled the entire government with a popular vote and wrote the protection of the moors into the Constitution itself. Hold both truths. Switzerland's distinctive power is real and rare: direct democracy, the right of citizens to force a public vote — on a constitutional amendment, on a law, and, most powerfully for a local project, at the commune and canton — together with the strong autonomy of cantons and communes and the statutory appeal rights of environmental organisations. And the constraint is real: direct democracy cuts both ways — many environmental initiatives have lost, and a vote you lose can legitimise the very project you opposed, while every vote takes signatures, money, coalitions, and time.

Here's the discipline that wins. Build the broadest, most unlikely coalition you can — the conservative farmers and urban environmentalists whose alliance won Rothenthurm — because breadth is what wins a Swiss vote. Choose the right level: for a local project, the commune or canton ballot, where direct democracy bites hardest and a vote is most winnable; for a law or a lasting protection, a referendum or a popular initiative. Assess honestly whether the vote can be won, and don't force one you'll lose, because a loss can legitimise the project — use the environmental organisations' appeal rights, the planning law, and the courts instead. Then run a disciplined, accurate campaign to win the public. Count a project stopped at the ballot, a protection written in, and an appeal won as wins. That's what Rothenthurm did — direct democracy, an unlikely coalition, and the appeal rights together, wielded with the judgement to win. So can you.